
FW: Automated License Plate Readers (Flock) and LSPD

From Mark Dunning <Mark.Dunning@cityofls.net>

Date Mon 8/17/2026 5:04 PM

To CityCouncil <CityCouncil@cityofls.net>

Cc Travis Forbes <Travis.Forbes@cityofls.net>; City Manager's Office <CityMgrsOffice@cityofls.net>

Mayor Lopez and City Councilmembers,

Forwarding on this information provided by Chief Forbes for your awareness. Chief Forbes will be prepared to share information during staff roundtable at tomorrow night's meeting as well, so the public has awareness of our policies, procedures, and utilization of ALPRs in Lee's Summit.

Thank you,

Mark Dunning, City Manager, MPA

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From: Travis Forbes <Travis.Forbes@cityofls.net>

Sent: Monday, August 17, 2026 3:09 PM

To: City Manager's Office <CityMgrsOffice@cityofls.net>

Subject: Automated License Plate Readers (Flock) and LSPD

Mayor and City Councilmembers,

I am aware that there has been considerable public discussion and concern expressed regarding the use of automated license plate reader (ALPR) technology. Given that interest, I wanted to provide you with clear information on our current practices, the safeguards in place, and the reasoning behind our data retention approach so you have accurate context as these conversations continue.

Executive Summary

After reviewing investigative needs, community input, and current best practices, the Police Department is retaining its ALPR data for **30 days**. This period supports effective follow-up on serious crimes (including recent homicides, robberies, child exploitation cases, and an AMBER Alert) while remaining consistent with Missouri legal considerations and our existing privacy safeguards. The Department has had no policy violations since implementation, maintains a public Transparency Hub detailing strict usage rules, and continues to emphasize human verification, access logging, and regular audits. We believe this approach balances public safety with responsible data handling.

Discussion

While I understand that the establishment of procedures and use of investigative technologies is primarily at the discretion of police department leadership, I also know that many of you have

received inquiries from some constituents regarding the department's use of automated license plate reader (ALPR) systems.

It is our goal to establish a data retention policy that is reasonable, and after review we consider this period to be sufficient to meet most investigative purposes and to help us keep Lee's Summit safe. With this in mind, we are currently keeping our data retention policy at 30-days, in line with best practices and legal considerations in the State of Missouri. I have made this decision based on feedback from our criminal investigators of the value of the data in helping solve felony cases and best serve crime victims.

ALPR technology remains a vital investigative tool. It has assisted our department in cases involving homicides, robberies, child exploitation, and, just last week, an AMBER Alert. The ability to quickly develop leads on serious and time-sensitive crimes directly supports our responsibility to protect the community. Retaining this capability is important to public safety in Lee's Summit.

Crime sprees rarely remain invisible for long. Once investigators recognize a pattern of related incidents, whether through multiple reports, officer observations, or citizen tips, they can immediately search the ALPR database, pull the relevant plate reads, and preserve them in the case file. The 30-day window routinely covers the period when these connections surface and initial investigative steps are taken.

The same mechanism addresses crimes that are not promptly discovered or reported. Property crimes, hit-and-runs, and similar offenses are frequently brought to the Department's attention within days or a few weeks of occurrence. When a report is taken, authorized users can query the still-available ALPR data, identify vehicles of interest, and move those records into the permanent case file before the automatic purge. The policy therefore does not depend on every crime being reported the same day it occurs; it depends on investigators acting once the crime becomes known.

This 30-day period is fully consistent with the Missouri Retention and Disposition Schedules filed under Chapter 109 RSMo. The Department retains and disposes of ALPR data in strict accordance with those state-filed schedules, ensuring both legal compliance and operational practicality.

At the same time, we recognize the need to balance investigative value with responsible data handling. Our current standards reflect that balance while preserving the system's operational usefulness.

Our Department maintains a public Transparency Hub that clearly outlines how the system is used and the safeguards in place. Key elements include:

- **Data ownership and use** — All data is owned by the Lee's Summit Police Department and is used exclusively for legitimate law enforcement purposes. It is never sold to third parties.
- **What the system does and does not do** — The technology detects license plates and vehicles only. It does **not** use facial recognition and does not identify people, gender, or race.
- **Prohibited uses** — The system may not be used for immigration enforcement, traffic enforcement, harassment or intimidation, any purpose based solely on a protected class, or personal use.
- **Access controls** — Every search requires a valid reason, and all access is logged and retained indefinitely for auditing purposes. Audits are conducted regularly.
- **Human verification** — Hotlist alerts must be verified by a human before any enforcement action is taken.

- **Retention** — Data is retained for 30 days on a rolling basis unless it is specifically archived as part of an active investigation or case. This period supports effective follow-up on serious crimes while limiting how long information is held.

These policies, combined with regular oversight and the public Transparency Hub itself, form the foundation of our approach to responsible use. We believe this framework provides meaningful transparency and accountability while preserving a tool that has proven valuable in protecting the community.

Transparency Hub: <https://transparency.flocksafety.com/lees-summit-mo-pd>

Since implementing the system, the Lee's Summit Police Department has had no violations of our ALPR policies. While we are aware of reported misuse in other agencies across the country, it is encouraging that those incidents have been taken seriously and addressed through appropriate administrative and, in some cases, legal action against the individuals involved. Misuse of any protected data is a serious issue and should be handled through strong internal controls. These reports reinforce the importance of strong policy, auditing, supervision, and accountability—practices we remain committed to upholding.

A few broader points are worth noting as technology continues to evolve:

- Artificial intelligence tools are already present in public safety and will only expand. ALPR is one application among many.
- Law enforcement agencies routinely handle extensive amounts of confidential information—far beyond ALPR data. Any misuse of that information is a serious matter and is addressed through investigation, policy, the legal system, and discipline.
- Other professions that hold sensitive data, including medicine and education, face similar responsibilities. The most effective protections in all of these fields remain strong policy, regular auditing, active supervision, and accountability. There must be a reasonable degree of trust in any field or institution that holds this type of protected data, and this trust can be bolstered by strong oversight mechanisms (present with the administration of our ALPR system).
- Some community members will continue to distrust the handling of confidential data regardless of the safeguards in place. While we take legitimate concerns seriously and will continue to refine our practices, it is not realistic to expect that every concern can be fully resolved to everyone's satisfaction. It is unreasonable to distrust law enforcement's handling of investigative data to the extent that it is removed completely from the tools that we use to help keep Lee's Summit safe.
- Beyond dedicated ALPR systems, modern AI can extract a wide range of identifiers from any ordinary video footage. The proliferation of both public and private cameras in public access areas, including roadways, has greatly expanded the availability of video footage worldwide. This reality reinforces the need for consistent, strong practices around data access, retention, and oversight—practices we are committed to maintaining.
- Crime victims served by these systems are rarely heard from, but they exist. These systems have prevented numerous crimes, solved cases that would have otherwise been closed, and helped save lives.

As an organization dedicated to following evidence-based practices and serving crime victims with robust investigative tools, we will continue to monitor both the effectiveness of the system and the adequacy of our privacy controls.

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